CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

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RE: Fiji committee defers Australia treaty ratification · RBA at 4.85pc, 18-year high · New Zealand votes Saturday · Samoa pressed at UN on press freedom · Marshall Islands gets $11m World Bank package

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
9,065	0.7017	14,091	0.5636
+1.95%	-0.14%	+2.78%	+0.07%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · AUKUS · Pacific · New Zealand · Canberra · Markets · Documents · Upcoming · The Wire · Analysis

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Fiji's Standing Committee on Foreign Affairs and Defence recommended deferring ratification of the Vuvale Union and the Ocean of Peace Alliance, the two agreements signed with Australia in July, and Prime Minister Sitiveni Rabuka says he will pursue another route.
2. The Reserve Bank lifted the cash rate to 4.85 percent, its fifth increase this year and the highest level in 18 years, with deputy governor Andrew Hauser conceding trust in the bank's near-term ability to hit its targets has fallen materially.
3. New Zealanders vote on Saturday with both major parties shedding support, and Christopher Luxon has ruled out NZ First candidate Michael Laws from any ministry in a future government.

TOP STORIES

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Fijian committee recommends deferring ratification of the Vuvale Union and Ocean of Peace Alliance

Fiji's parliamentary Standing Committee on Foreign Affairs and Defence told legislators on Wednesday that ratification of the two agreements signed with Australia in July should be deferred, with its chairperson **Lenora Qereqeretabua**, who is also deputy speaker and assistant minister of foreign affairs, delivering the recommendation. **Anthony Albanese** had described the treaty as "one of the most significant endeavours" undertaken by Canberra. Prime Minister **Sitiveni Rabuka** said he was "very disappointed" and would pursue "another route" to get the agreements ratified. Traditional leader **Ratu Tevita Mara** had urged lawmakers in September to vote both down.

per RNZ Pacific: "Parliamentary committee puts ratification of Fiji-Australia security treaty on hold" · also ABC Pacific

TRADE-ECONOMY

RBA deputy governor concedes public trust in the inflation fight is slipping

The Reserve Bank's Monetary Policy Board lifted the cash rate to *4.85 percent* this week, up from 4.6 percent and the highest level in 18 years, in a majority decision. Deputy governor **Andrew Hauser** said a bank survey showed trust in its near-term ability to meet its monetary policy objectives had "fallen materially", while overall trust remained "high and stable", adding that "consumer confidence is exceptionally weak". The AFR reports board members privately rebuked Hauser for signalling a fortnight before the meeting that rates were very likely to rise.

per ABC News: "Deputy governor concedes RBA is losing Australians' trust to manage inflation" · also AFR

NZ-POLITICS

New Zealand votes Saturday with support for both major parties cratering

Support for National and Labour, led by **Christopher Luxon** and **Chris Hipkins**, is falling on dissatisfaction with the economy, leaving minor parties positioned to benefit from a desire for change. Reuters reported leaders making final appeals with the race still tight. Bloomberg reports the New Zealand dollar's slide is weighing on both main parties days out from the vote, which falls on Saturday, November 7, 2026.

per The New York Times: "The New Zealand Election That Could 'Flip the Table'" · also Reuters

OVERNIGHT

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Pressure builds on Canberra over refined fuel made from Russian crude · Sydney Morning Herald

Australia has not banned imports of refined petroleum originating from Moscow's crude oil, despite repeated warnings and Senate findings, the Herald reports. Critics describe the country as "a dumping ground for blood oil". The gap sits alongside Australia's existing sanctions architecture on Russia.

AU-POLITICS

National survey records opposition to migration at its highest level · Sydney Morning Herald

A landmark national survey reveals record opposition to migration and rising prejudice against Muslims and Jews, propelled by the populist right, according to the Herald's **Natassia Chrysanthos**. The reporting ties the shift to gains for **Pauline Hanson**'s One Nation.

US-AUSTRALIA

Canberra plans for a rockier final two years of the Trump presidency · Sydney Morning Herald

The US president's electoral thrashing in the midterms could bring him to heel, the Herald writes, but Australian officials are not counting on it. Democrats took control of both chambers of Congress this week, a result Australian commentary has read as a referendum on **Donald Trump** himself.

TRADE-ECONOMY

Australia's trade surplus heads for a decade low on chip and energy imports · Bloomberg

Rising imports of semiconductors and energy are pushing Australia's trade surplus towards its weakest level in ten years, Bloomberg reports. The squeeze lands as the Reserve Bank raises rates into an inflation fight it expects to run longer than previously flagged.

STAT OF THE DAY

4.85%

RBA cash rate after this week's increase

The fifth rise this year takes the rate to its highest level in 18 years, with the deputy governor conceding public trust in the inflation fight has fallen materially.

ABC News

AUKUS WATCH

PILLAR 1 · POLITICO

Politico carries the unofficial AUKUS inquiry's call to tear up the submarine pact to Washington

Politico reported the findings of the crowd-funded, unofficial inquiry that recommended scrapping AUKUS, describing it as the "worst" defence decision the country has ever made. This brief carried the inquiry's release and former Chief of the Defence Force Chris Barrie's ABC remarks on November 4; the development is the story's pickup by a Washington masthead. The Saturday Paper also wrote the inquiry up.

PACIFIC WIRE

FIJI · FBC NEWS

Fiji weighs a centralised national intelligence system

Minister for Defence **Pio Tikoduadua** told parliament the government is considering a centralised national intelligence system and that a comprehensive review of the country's intelligence structure is underway. Intelligence is currently collected and analysed across several government agencies.

FIJI · RNZ PACIFIC

Rabuka plays down drought as Fiji's met service warns of strong El Niño into 2027

Asked outside parliament in Suva about severe dry spells across Vanua Levu and the maritime islands, **Sitiveni Rabuka** replied: "Are people dying? No. We can manage." The Fiji Meteorological Service says El Niño conditions are likely to reach very strong intensity and persist through the remainder of 2026 and early 2027, with below-normal rainfall forecast and wildfire risk rising.

SAMOA · RNZ PACIFIC

Ten countries raise Samoa's media restrictions at its UN periodic review

Press freedom came under scrutiny at Samoa's periodic review in Geneva this week, with *ten countries*, including some of its largest donor partners and former colonial powers, raising government media restrictions. Prime Minister **La'aulialemalietoa Leuatea Schmidt** has banned the Samoa Observer from his press conferences, and a draft Media Protocol would require journalists to submit questions 24 hours ahead for government vetting and undergo background checks.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · ABC PACIFIC

Solomon Islands constitutional reform would restrict no-confidence motions

Proposed constitutional changes in Solomon Islands seek to restrict motions of no confidence, ABC Pacific Beat reports. No-confidence motions have repeatedly reshaped Solomon Islands governments in recent parliaments.

MARSHALL ISLANDS · ISLANDS BUSINESS

World Bank releases $11 million for Marshall Islands El Niño and dengue response

The World Bank Group has released *$US11 million* to help the Marshall Islands respond to worsening El Niño conditions and an ongoing dengue outbreak. The package lands as meteorological services across the region warn of a strong El Niño persisting into early 2027.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Twenty-five PNG public servants quit to contest the 2027 national elections

Twenty-five Papua New Guinea public servants, including one woman, have formally resigned their positions to contest the 2027 National Elections. The departures strip experienced administrators from the bureaucracy more than a year before polling.

COOK ISLANDS · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Met services and media from four states meet in Rarotonga on early warnings

Meteorological services and media representatives from Fiji, the Cook Islands, Tuvalu and Tonga are meeting in Rarotonga for five days to strengthen climate early warning communication. The workshop runs as drought and dengue responses draw donor funding across the region.

MICRONESIA (FSM) · THE NEW YORK TIMES

Five survivors of a Micronesian boat missing since July land in Kiribati

A boat that went missing in Micronesia in July delivered five of its passengers, unclothed and emaciated, onto an island in Kiribati at the weekend, more than *3,000 miles* away. The United States Coast Guard had been involved in the search.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Luxon rules Michael Laws out of any ministry, Peters calls it "another frustration"

Christopher Luxon swiftly ruled out NZ First candidate **Michael Laws** from serving as a minister after remarks mocking women in the Opportunity Party surfaced on Wednesday. **Winston Peters** called the comments "simply unacceptable" but said Luxon's intervention was "somebody trying to assert their authority", adding there was "no such thing" as a National government under MMP. Opportunity leader **Qiulae Wong** called for Laws to stand down.

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

New Zealand posts its biggest annual house-price drop in 19 months

House prices fell at their fastest annual pace in 19 months, Bloomberg reports, days before Saturday's vote. Economic dissatisfaction is the dominant theme of the campaign in both major parties' polling.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ PACIFIC

Employment Court rules migrant workers can challenge offshore recruitment fees

An Employment Court ruling has established that migrant workers can legally challenge unlawful recruitment fees paid overseas to secure jobs in New Zealand. The decision closes a loophole exploited by recruiters, with implications for Pacific labour mobility schemes.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · SYDNEY MORNING HERALD

Herald reports prime minister and treasurer tensions sharpening as the economy bites

The usual tensions between prime minister and treasurer, which simmer when a government looks cooked, could boil over, the Herald writes, with **Anthony Albanese** and **Jim Chalmers** both under pressure after this week's rate rise. The piece argues one of the two could be gone before the next election.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Albanese abroad for summits as the rate rise lands at home

The prime minister has little choice about attending a run of overseas conferences and summits, the ABC writes, but the timing coincides with another interest rate rise shuddering through the economy. ABC analysis says Labor is using MYEFO to buy time politically ahead of 2028.

AU-POLITICS · AUSTRALIAN FINANCIAL REVIEW

Federal public service wage bill rose more than 7 percent last year

Commonwealth spending on public servant salaries increased by *more than 7 percent* last year, the AFR reports, intensifying pressure on **Jim Chalmers** to rein in hiring. The figure lands while the government is managing expectations on spending restraint.

AU-POLITICS · SYDNEY MORNING HERALD

Joyce talks down One Nation's Victorian prospects before polling day

Barnaby Joyce says Labor preferences will flow to the Liberals in Victoria and that the real litmus test of One Nation's rise will be next year's New South Wales election, the Herald's **Paul Sakkal** reports.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

High Court agrees to hear Hanson's racial discrimination case against Faruqi

The High Court has agreed to hear the racism dispute between One Nation leader **Pauline Hanson** and Greens senator **Mehreen Faruqi**, The Australian reports. The case follows earlier federal court findings in the long-running litigation between the two senators.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

China audits Australia's canola supply chain in a sign of trade thaw

Chinese authorities are auditing Australia's canola supply chain, which Bloomberg reads as a sign of further thaw in the trade relationship. Canola was among the commodities caught in Beijing's earlier restrictions on Australian exports.

TRADE-ECONOMY · AUSTRALIAN FINANCIAL REVIEW

Infrastructure pipeline nears a record $870 billion, with 37 data centre builds

The value of infrastructure projects under construction could approach a record *$870 billion* in 2027, with 37 data centre builds now in the pipeline, the AFR reports. The capacity pressure feeds directly into the Reserve Bank's inflation problem.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Woodside to cut more than 500 jobs while prioritising AI

Woodside will shed more than 500 jobs as it promises shareholders bigger returns and prioritises artificial intelligence, The Australian reports. The company recently moved to exit its Timor-Leste gas project.

TRADE-ECONOMY · REUTERS

NEXTDC shares rally as it calls the Goodman and Digital Realty bid opportunistic

Australian data centre operator NEXTDC rallied after rejecting a share bid from Goodman and Digital Realty as "opportunistic", Reuters reports. Data centre capacity is now a visible component of Australia's construction pipeline.

PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

READOUT · AUSTRALIAN MINISTER FOR FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Wong announces sanctions on senior commanders responsible for the Sudan conflict

Foreign Minister **Penny Wong** announced Australian sanctions on senior commanders responsible for the conflict in Sudan. The listing extends Australia's autonomous sanctions regime beyond its Indo-Pacific focus.

UPCOMING

NOV 7

New Zealand general election

Polling shows both major parties losing ground, putting minor parties in position to decide the next government and its foreign and defence settings.

NOV 2026

New Zealand government formation talks after Saturday's vote

NZ First and the Opportunity Party are both positioned as potential kingmakers, and the Michael Laws row has already strained National-NZ First relations.

NOV 2026

Rabuka's next move on ratifying the Vuvale Union and Ocean of Peace Alliance

The Fijian prime minister says he will pursue "another route" after his own parliament's committee recommended deferral of the two Australian treaties.

NOV 2026

Pacific climate early-warning workshop concludes in Rarotonga

Met services from Fiji, Cook Islands, Tuvalu and Tonga are coordinating drought and cyclone messaging as a strong El Niño persists into 2027.

THE WIRE

AU-DEFENSE

ASPI STRATEGIST

For Australia, the most important PLA element is Southern Theater Command

If war over Taiwan erupts, Australia could face elements of the People's Liberation Army Southern Theater Command, the Strategist argues, urging planners to move beyond generalities about defending the northern approaches.

ASPI STRATEGIST

Fiscal flexibility is a national security issue

Five interest rate increases this year have squeezed households, the Strategist writes, but the larger problem is governments losing the fiscal headroom to respond to strategic shocks.

TRADE-ECONOMY

LOWY INTERPRETER

APEC 2026: Let's get back to the future on trade

With global trade rules stuck, a 1990s APEC model offers Australia a practical way to rebuild trust and momentum, the Interpreter argues.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

ISLANDS BUSINESS

Pacific women are already doing the work, COP31 must back them

Islands Business argues climate finance at COP31 should reach the Pacific women already running community resilience and ocean work, invoking Epeli Hau'ofa's framing of the sea as the source of Pacific life.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

ISLANDS BUSINESS

Tongan-American Republican Doug Fiefia wins a Utah state Senate seat

Republican **Doug Fiefia** secured victory in Utah's Senate District 18, making history for Tongan-Americans in the state, Islands Business reports.

ANALYSIS AND OPINION

NOT STATED IN FEED · THE DIPLOMAT

How Some Media Shape Regional Australia's Hostility to Renewable Energy

The piece traces research into how particular media outlets link climate-delay framing to fossil-fuel interests and to regional audiences. It argues this circuit is reshaping energy policy debate outside the capitals and eroding trust in institutions.

Argument: Partisan outlets connect climate-delay narratives, fossil-fuel interests, and regional audiences, reshaping energy debates and public trust.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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↑ BACK TO TOP

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